

MOTHER AND BABY

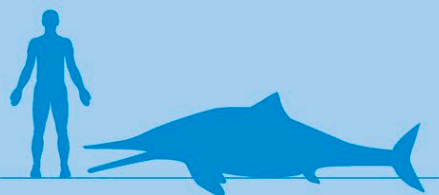
STENOPTERYGIUS

While the dinosaurs dominated the land, ichthyosaurs ruled the seas. Although they had descended from land-dwelling creatures, ichthyosaurs were well adapted to their marine environment. Most modern-day reptiles lay eggs on dry land, but ichthyosaurs, such as this *Stenopterygius*, gave birth to live young. This well-preserved fossil shows a *Stenopterygius* mother giving birth. It appears from the fossil that ichthyosaurs gave birth to their offspring tail first, which protected the newborns from drowning before they could take their first breath.

Stenopterygius's long snout helped it snap up small fish and squid.

AT A GLANCE

- **YEAR OF DISCOVERY** 1856
- **PLACE** Holzmaden, Germany
- **FOUND BY** Friedrich Quenstedt
- **LIVED** 183 MYA



Paddlelike forelimbs acted as rudders, steering *Stenopterygius* through the water.

